

portfolio manager in his right mind would recommend a stock called Pep Boys—Manny, Moe, and Jack—unless of course the Street already realizes how profitable it is, and by then it's up tenfold already.

Blurting out that you own Pep Boys won't get you much of an audience at a cocktail party, but whisper "GeneSplice International" and everybody listens. Meanwhile, GeneSplice International is going no-where but down, while Pep Boys—Manny, Moe, and Jack just keeps going higher.

If you discover an opportunity early enough, you probably get a few dollars off the price just for the dull or odd name, which is why I'm always on the lookout for the Pep Boys or the Bob Evanses, or the occasional Consolidated Rock. Too bad that wonderful aggregate company changed its name to Conrock and then the trendier Calmat. As long as it was Consolidated Rock, nobody paid attention to it.

(2) IT DOES SOMETHING DULL

I get even more excited when a company with a boring name also does something boring. Crown, Cork, and Seal makes cans and bottle caps. What could be duller than that? You won't see an interview with the CEO of Crown, Cork, and Seal in *Time* magazine alongside an interview with Lee Iacocca, but that's a plus. There's nothing boring about what's happened to the shares of Crown, Cork, and Seal.

I already mentioned Seven Oaks International, the company that processes the coupons that you hand in at the grocery store. There's another tale that's guaranteed to shut your eyes—as the stock sneaks up from \$4 to \$33. Seven Oaks International and Crown, Cork, and Seal make IBM seem like a Las Vegas revue, and how about Agency Rent-A-Car? That's the glamorous outfit that provides the car the insurance company lets you drive while yours is being repaired. Agency Rent-A-Car came public at \$4 a share and Wall Street hardly noticed. What self-respecting tycoon would want to think about what people drive while their cars are in the shop? The Agency Rent-A-Car prospectus could have been marketed as an anesthetic, but the last time I looked, the stock was \$16.

A company that does boring things is almost as good as a company that has a boring name, and both together is terrific. Both together is guaranteed to keep the oxymorons away until finally the good news compels them to buy in, thus sending the stock price even higher. If a company with terrific earnings and a strong balance sheet also does dull things, it gives you a lot of time to purchase the stock at a discount. Then when it becomes trendy and overpriced, you can sell your shares to the trend-followers.